

Digging in THE DIRT

Gowda is locked in a bitter political battle with Yeddyurappa to ensure that the rural messiah tag stays in his family

| By Stephen David |

A quirk of fate may have landed him the prime minister's job in 1996, but by no stretch of the imagination does Haradanahalli Doddegowda Deve Gowda come anywhere near to being a role model as a politician. Among his many attributes were a tendency to doze off during Cabinet meetings and crucial Parliament sessions and his ability to keep expletives intact when talking about political opponents.

Last week, he dragged the level of his own political discourse to a new low when he called Karnataka's BJP Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa a "bloody b*****d". Soon, BJP workers fanned out in protest across the state. Though Gowda's son and former chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy was candid enough to admit that his father was feeling the "stress" of being out of office for long, Gowda initially refused to apologise. Later, he relented and expressed his regrets.

The weekend diatribe between Gowda and Yeddyurappa, both self-styled rural leaders, is about two powerful community leaders wanting to wrest control of the state. After his stint in Delhi politics, Gowda and family know that it pays to be regional strongmen. Yeddyurappa, thanks to his loyalty to the RSS that provides security to his seat of power and his own revulsion to be part of national poli-

tics, is content playing Karnataka CEO.

Gowda is clearly visualising another shot at power; if not for himself, at least for his family. His threat is neither from the BJP that has its own internal dissensions and power centres to contend with, nor from the Congress, whose high command has a low connect with the state unit. Gowda's menace is Yeddyurappa, the most visible face of the state's largest community, the Lingayats. Gowda is the most active player from Karnataka's second largest caste bloc, the Vokkaligas.

Yeddyurappa hates being linked to

his caste but the fact is that over a dozen state chief ministers—from K.C. Reddy to Yeddyurappa—have been from the Lingayat and the Vokkaliga communities. The fight is between Yeddyurappa, the face of the BJP here, and Gowda, the JD(s) chief.

After nearly six decades in politics, Gowda had planned to retire and write a warts-and-all autobiography. His sons H.D. Revanna was a Cabinet minister while Kumaraswamy is now a Lok Sabha member from Bangalore Rural constituency. Kumaraswamy's wife Anitha, a computer science engineer, became the



BK RAMESH

BJP WORKERS
PROTEST GOWDA'S
DIATRIBE AGAINST
YEDDYURAPPA